NEPAL'S FLYING COFFINS

ALL 72 PEOPLE WERE KILLED WHEN A YETI AIRLINES FLIGHT WENT DOWN ON JANUARY 15 NEAR POKHARA IN CENTRAL NEPAL. IT WAS THE LATEST OF NUMEROUS PLANE CRASHES IN THE COUNTRY OVER THE DECADES

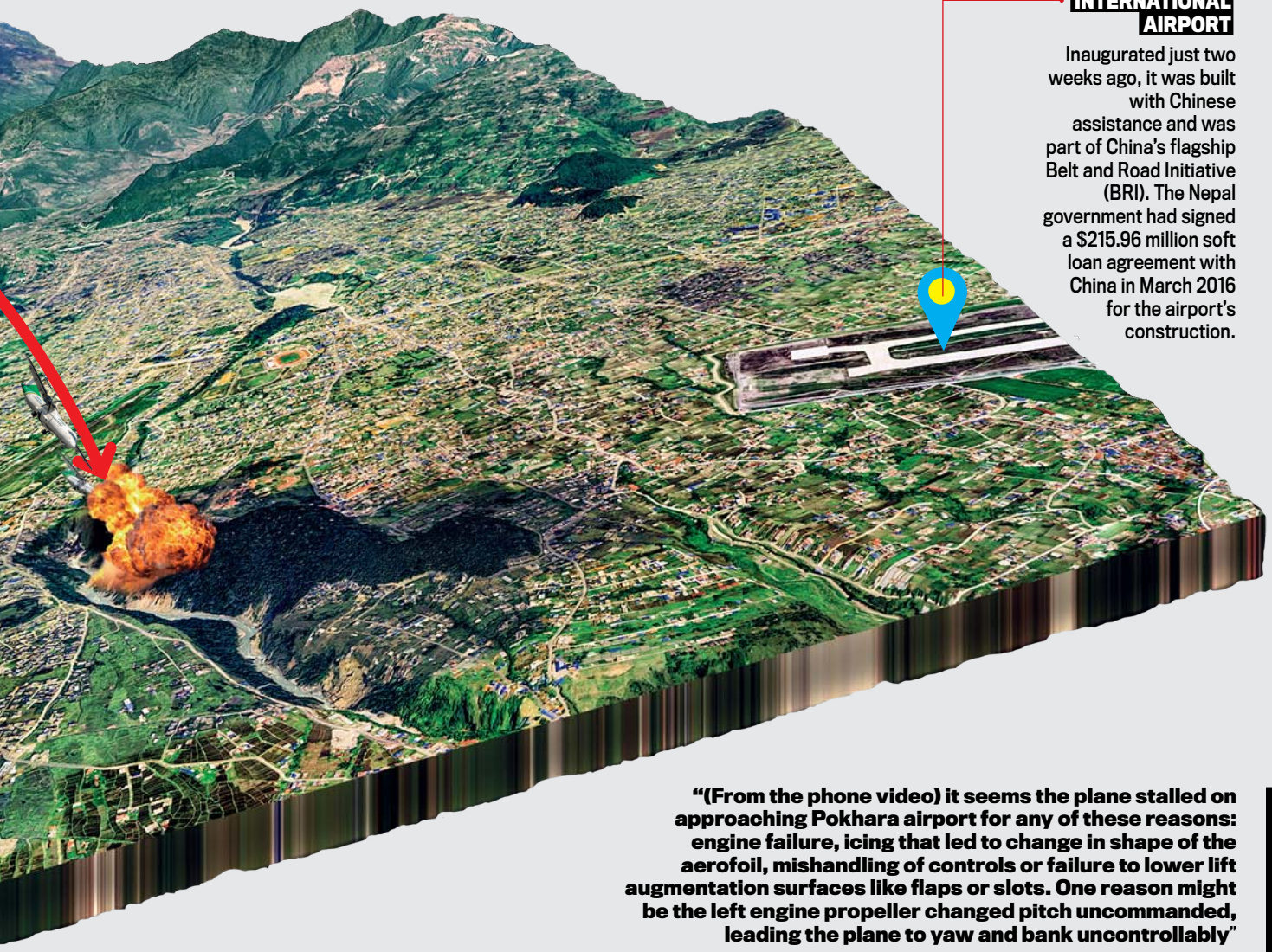
Graphic by **NILANJAN DAS**

THE WEATHER

The pilot did not report "anything untoward" as the plane approached the airport. The mountains were clear, "visibility was good", a light wind was blowing. Why the plane crashed then is a matter requiring investigation

POKHARA INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT

Inaugurated just two weeks ago, it was built with Chinese assistance and was part of China's flagship Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). The Nepal government had signed a $215.96 million soft loan agreement with China in March 2016 for the airport's construction.



"(From the phone video) it seems the plane stalled on approaching Pokhara airport for any of these reasons: engine failure, icing that led to change in shape of the aerofoil, mishandling of controls or failure to lower lift augmentation surfaces like flaps or slots. One reason might be the left engine propeller changed pitch uncommanded, leading the plane to yaw and bank uncontrollably"

– A FORMER IAF FIGHTER PILOT,
now flying commercial aircraft, speaking to India Today

MAY 2015
A US Marine Corps Bell UH-1Y Venom chopper crashed in Charikot during a relief effort following the devastating earthquake. All 13 perons aboard were killed

FEB. 2016
An aircraft carrying 11 passengers crashed in Kalikot district of Nepal. Two crew members were killed, nine other passengers were injured

MARCH 2018
A US-Bangla airline crashed at Tribhuvan International Airport, with 67 passengers aboard, of which 49 were killed

FEB. 2019
An Air Dynasty helicopter collided with a hill killing all seven on board, including Nepal's then tourism minister Rabindra Adhikari

MAY 2022
A Yeti Airlines plane with 22 passengers on board, including three crew members, crashed in Mustang district. All were killed

Source: flightradar24.com; Nepal Government spokesperson; Cirium Fleets; *Kathmandu Post* and other media sources